PARTICIPANT HANDOUT | LESSON 14

2 Corinthians Part 2

Strength Made Perfect in Weakness

BIG IDEA The grace of Christ creates generous people and faithful servants who boast not in themselves but in Christ's power displayed through weakness.

Series location: Lesson 14 of 24 | 2 Corinthians 8-13

Primary texts: 2 Corinthians 8:1-15; 9:6-15; 10:3-5; 11:1-33; 12:7-10; 13:5-14

Series question: What problem is Paul addressing, and how does the gospel answer it?

Follow the movement

PASSAGE	MOVEMENT
8:1-9:15	Grace produces willing generosity, transparent stewardship, and thanksgiving to God.
10:1-18	Gospel authority demolishes false arguments without using worldly weapons or self-promotion.
11:1-33	Paul exposes false apostles and turns boasting into a catalogue of costly service and weakness.
12:1-13:14	Christ's sufficient grace rests on weak servants, and apostolic authority builds up the church.

Grace-shaped generosity

CHARACTERISTIC	GOSPEL SHAPE
Willing	Give without manipulation, resentment, or compulsion.
Proportionate	God accepts the gift according to what a person has.
Sacrificial	Grace may produce costly generosity, but hardship is not a mandatory formula.
Directed toward need	Abundance supplies need so that God's people have sufficiency.
Rooted in Christ	Christ embraced incarnation and the cross so that sinners receive salvation's riches.

Sowing and reaping

God supplies sufficiency so that believers can abound in good works. The harvest of generosity includes needs met, further generosity, righteousness, fellowship, thanksgiving, and glory to God. Paul does not promise that every giver will become personally wealthy.

FINANCIAL INTEGRITY Paul used multiple trusted representatives and visible procedures. Christian stewardship should be honorable before God and people.

BEFORE NEXT WEEK Read Romans 1-4. Mark humanity's problem, God's righteousness, the role of faith, and Paul's use of Abraham.

The cross overturns impressive ministry

WORLDLY MEASURE	PAUL'S CRUCIFORM BOAST
Pedigree and credentials	Paul can match them but refuses to build ministry upon them.
Commanding presence	He serves with the meekness and gentleness of Christ.
Visions and visible power	He recounts suffering, danger, weakness, and concern for the churches.
Triumphant public image	He ends with an undignified escape through a window in a basket.

The super-apostles offered impressive claims but proclaimed another Jesus, a different spirit, and a different gospel. Spiritual appearance cannot compensate for a distorted gospel, exploitation, or self-promoting authority.

The thorn and sufficient grace

WHAT WE CANNOT KNOW	WHAT THE TEXT MAKES CLEAR
Whether the thorn was illness, opposition, persecution, temptation, or another affliction	It was painful, persistent, and used by God to prevent conceit.
A specific medical diagnosis or named opponent	Paul prayed repeatedly for removal and received sustaining grace.
Why God handles every believer's suffering differently	Christ's power reaches its intended display in human weakness.

'My grace is sufficient for you' does not minimize pain, forbid prayer, or reject practical help. Christ promises enough grace for faithful endurance when deliverance is delayed or denied.

Authority that builds up

Paul tells the Corinthians to examine whether they remain in the apostolic faith and whether Christ is genuinely among them. His authority can correct and discipline, but its purpose is restoration and the building up of Christ's church.

The Gospel Then and Now

THEN AND NOW	GOSPEL RESPONSE
Pressure then	Corinth admired patronage, credentials, polished rhetoric, and visible power.
Temptation now	We may measure ministry by platform, fundraising, charisma, growth, or constant victory.
Faithful ministry	Grace gives freely, practices integrity, accepts weakness, and uses authority to restore.

Discuss

1. How does generosity make the unity of Christ's church visible?
2. What keeps sowing and reaping from becoming a prosperity formula?
3. What worldly measures of successful ministry still attract Christians?
4. Why does Paul boast in weakness rather than simply refuse to boast?
5. How can sufficient grace encourage sufferers without minimizing their pain?

FOR FURTHER STUDY
Related: Exodus 16:13-18; Galatians 2:10; 1 Corinthians 16:1-4; Romans 15:25-28
ECO: Essential Tenets III.C, III.D, III.E | Class resources: scan QR.